CAREER GLITCH · SHORT · SIMPLE · NO BORING PARTS

CYBERSECURITY ANALYST IN THE AI ERA

Every company is now a target, and attackers use AI too — defense is a growth job with a human at the console. Just not at the rung the course ads point at.

★ TL;DR — Median $129,180, growth +21%, ~14,100 openings a year (BLS, Information Security Analysts, May 2025) — the strongest YES in this batch. The honest entry band: the bottom 10% of the occupation earns under $75,090, and a first seat prices at or below it. The catch: there is no no-cert, no-degree shortcut to the analyst median — anyone selling one is selling the exact promise the workforce data refutes. ★

THE CAREER GLITCH TAKE

OUR TAKE: YES

MEDIAN ~$125K · TRAINING 4+ years · AI RISK MEDIUM

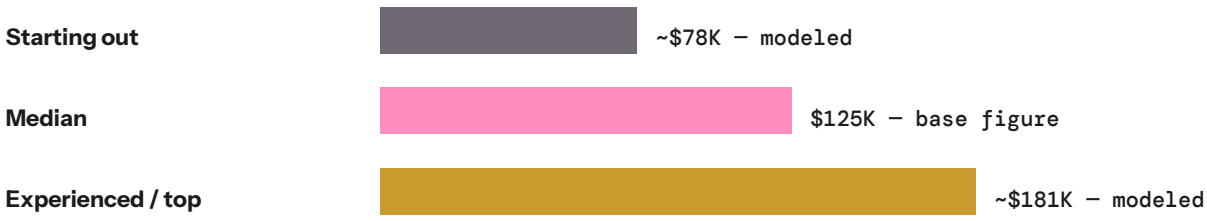
- The demand is official, not marketing: BLS projects +21% and names AI itself as a driver ('Increased use of artificial intelligence (AI)… increased the need for enhanced security'), WEF lists the occupation among its fastest-growing roles, and CyberSeek counted 514,359 US listings against a 74% supply/demand ratio. The openings are real.

- They are also mostly not for beginners yet: ISC2's workforce research found 31% of security teams had NO entry-level professionals at all, and hiring concentrates at mid-to-advanced level. BLS's typical entry is a bachelor's degree plus related experience — the median belongs to that profile, and a first seat (Tier-1 SOC, MSSP analyst, DoD-contractor junior) prices at or below the $75,090 tenth percentile.

- The ground floor is being rebuilt under the occupation: SANS's research chief states the mechanical work — parsing logs, correlating alerts, first-pass triage — 'has mostly moved to the model,' and vendors market tens of hours of weekly triage eliminated. The surviving beginner product is one rung up: validate and tune what watches the queue, investigate what it escalates. Aim there from day one.

The site's take, built from this profession's numbers in the Career Glitch base.

THE MONEY — LOOK AT THE BARS



The Career Glitch base figure for Cybersecurity Analyst is a ~$125K median (compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). The starting and top bars are modeled around that median — orientation, not a promise. Pay swings hard by state, employer and experience: check live postings in your state before planning around any number.

WHAT DOES A CYBERSECURITY ANALYST ACTUALLY DO?

- ✓ Monitor alerts from security tools and decide what's real
- ✓ Investigate incidents: malware, phishing, suspicious logins
- ✓ Document everything — timelines, evidence, remediation
- ✓ Help harden systems so the same attack fails next time

Think: a security guard who reads logs instead of watching doors — the building is a network and the intruders are patient.

WHAT AI ALREADY TOOK (AND WHAT IT CAN'T)

THE ROBOT	THE HUMAN
AI triages alert floods, correlates logs, drafts incident reports and hunts known patterns at machine speed. Tier-1 alert sorting is being automated in production — CrowdStrike markets its AI's triage decisions as matching its own MDR experts at ~98% accuracy (vendor claim).	Judging the one alert that matters, containing a live incident, and explaining risk to executives who want a yes/no. Detection tools supply the who, what, when and where; the analyst supplies the why. Adversarial thinking stays human.

⚠ **THE SIX-MONTH ANALYST MIRAGE: 'Security+ in 6 months → $125K analyst' is the promise to refuse. Security+ is a real gate — it's the DoD 8140 baseline for federal and contractor seats — but it buys feeder-seat eligibility, not the analyst median. And CISSP can never be your first credential: ISC2 requires five years of domain experience before it can be held at all. The shortage headlines describe experienced people; your first seat is the whole battle, so budget for the degree-or-feeder route honestly.**

THE VIBE — IS THIS YOUR LIFE?

THE JOB IS	THE JOB IS NOT

✓ Mission you can feel — the work visibly matters ✓ Strong pay and remote options ✓ A field that changes monthly; boredom is impossible	✗ Alert fatigue is real and documented ✗ Incidents pick their own hours ✗ You are professionally paranoid now

Good fit? You're curious how systems break, patient with logs, calm when an incident goes loud — and patient enough to enter through the feeder seats the occupation actually hires.
Bad fit? You want a quiet, ticket-in ticket-out routine, or a certificate sprint with no degree and no IT past straight into a six-figure analyst seat.

THE FORK — PICK ONE DOOR

DOOR A — DEGREE OR IT FIRST, SECURITY SECOND	DOOR B — CERT-AND-LAB SPRINT, PRICED HONESTLY
The typical route BLS prices: a bachelor's in a computer-science field, or IT support/networking experience, with Security+ earned on the side — it is the DoD 8140 baseline qualification for the federal and contractor seats that form the deepest, most beginner-tolerant segment of demand (contractor juniors typically get a months-long window to qualify). Most SOC analysts arrive this way, and hiring managers trust the path.	No IT past? The sprint is real — IT fundamentals, Security+, a home lab and documented practice investigations — but buy it for what it is: eligibility for the feeder seats (Tier-1 SOC at an MSSP, contractor trainee roles), priced at or below $75,090 to start. It is the first step of the route, not the analyst seat, and the analysts who climb from it add degree-level depth and post-triage skills as they go.

Smart move: Publish your lab investigations: take a public malware sample or a capture-the-flag case, write the full analysis — including how you'd validate and tune the detection that caught it. One rigorous write-up aimed at the post-triage seat outweighs three certificate logos aimed at the triage queue.
Where you land after: SOC analyst → incident responder, threat hunter, security engineer — or the offensive side, penetration testing, reached from inside as a specialization rather than a starting title.

YOUR ROADMAP — 6 STEPS

1	2	3	4	5	6
IT FUNDAMENTAL	SECURITY+ —	HOME LAB	DOCUMENT INVESTIGATI	APPLY TO	SPECIALIZE AND

STEP 1 — IT fundamentals first

FREE–$100 · MONTHS 1–2

- Networking, operating systems, and how the web works — security sits on top of all three.
- If this layer is shaky, nothing above it will hold; helpdesk or support work builds it while paying you.

STEP 2 — Security+ — the baseline gate

$300–400 · MONTHS 2–5

- Earn the entry credential federal and contractor seats filter for: Security+ is the DoD 8140 foundational baseline.
- Study by building, not just reading: every concept gets a lab rep. (CISSP is not on this list — it legally requires five years of experience.)

STEP 3 — Home lab aimed past triage

FREE · MONTHS 3–6

- Virtual machines, a SIEM, sample logs and malware detonation in a sandbox.
- Practice validation, investigation and detection tuning — the work the models escalate to humans — not just queue-clearing.

STEP 4 — Document investigations

FREE · MONTHS 4–8

- Write up 3–4 investigations like real incident reports: evidence, timeline, judgment calls, remediation.
- This portfolio is your answer to the experience question, aimed at the post-triage seat.

STEP 5 — Apply to the seats that hire beginners

MONTHS 5–10

- SOC and security-analyst roles at MSSPs and large enterprises, DoD-contractor junior seats, and IT roles with security duties as a bridge.
- Budget the first seat at or below the $75,090 entry band — the median is earned later, on the degree-plus-experience profile.

STEP 6 — Specialize and stack the next credential

MONTHS 8–12

- Pick your lane: detection/response, cloud security, GRC or — from inside — offensive testing.
- Target the lane's credential next (CySA+ at the analyst tier); CISSP belongs years later, when its five-year experience rule is satisfied.

FIRST 90 DAYS — JUST DO THIS

 Today: install a virtual lab and find one real phishing email to dissect (headers, links, payload story).

 Days 1–30: networking and OS fundamentals daily; Security+ study started; feeder-seat postings collected and read honestly.

 Days 31–60: lab investigations underway — validation and tuning practice, not just alert-clearing; first full incident write-up published.

 Days 61–90: Security+ exam passed or booked; applications in for SOC, MSSP and contractor-junior seats.

 Day 90: a baseline credential, a lab, written proof of investigation skill — and applications aimed at the seats that actually hire beginners.

NEXT — MAKE IT PERSONAL

This roadmap is the same for everyone. Your life is not.

- Not sure this career fits YOU? Take the Big Career Test — 50 questions, your top-3 matches and one honest “probably NOT you”. → careerglitch.com/#test
- Already sure? Turn AI into Your Personal Career Mentor — a 2,300-word system that interviews you first, checks your hours, budget and deadline honestly, and builds YOUR plan into a Notion dashboard. → careerglitch.com/#prompt

★ ATTACKERS AUTOMATE. SO DO WE. JUDGMENT WINS. ★

CAREER GLITCH · Figures: Career Glitch profession base (medians and training ranges compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). Modeled bars are estimates around the base median. License and certification rules vary by state — verify with your state board before paying for any program.